

Module 4: Drivers of Migration

Signature Learning Experience

Purpose

Single-cause stories dominate public debate about why people migrate. In this case-mapping exercise, students take one real migration flow and build a layered map showing how economic, political, environmental, and violence-related drivers interact — replacing 'push/pull' lists with systems thinking.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Identify the key drivers present in one real flow (UG 1)
- Explain push/pull complexity beyond a two-column list (UG 2)
- Analyze a case with credible evidence for each claimed driver (UG 3)
- Recognize multi-causality and interaction effects (UG 4)

Graduate extension

Graduate students formalize the map into a causal loop diagram with every link evidenced, and write an evaluation of the dominant public narrative about their chosen flow against the mapped evidence (Grad 1–2).

Assignment steps

1. Choose one flow with instructor approval (e.g., Central America–US, Venezuela–Colombia, West Africa–Canary Islands, Myanmar–Bangladesh, climate-affected internal displacement in the Sahel).
2. Research the drivers using at least six credible sources: academic literature, UNHCR/IOM reporting, World Bank data, quality country reporting.
3. Draft the layered map: drivers grouped by type, with arrows showing how they interact (e.g., drought → crop failure → rural unemployment → gang recruitment pressure → flight). Every arrow needs a source.
4. Annotate the map: which drivers are proximate vs. structural? Which would remain if the most-cited driver disappeared?
5. Write the accompanying analysis explaining the map and what it reveals that the common narrative misses.
6. Present the map in a five-minute gallery walk; revise once based on peer and instructor feedback.

Deliverables & format

- One-page visual driver map (hand-drawn, slides, or diagram tool — clarity matters, polish doesn't)
- Written analysis, 1,200–1,500 words (graduate: 2,000+ with causal loop diagram and narrative evaluation)
- Source list with a one-line note on what each source evidenced

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Evidence quality — every mapped link supported 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: evidence quality — every mapped link supported is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: evidence quality — every mapped link supported is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: evidence quality — every mapped link supported is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: evidence quality — every mapped link supported is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Sophistication of interaction analysis, not just driver listing 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: sophistication of interaction analysis, not just driver listing goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: sophistication of interaction analysis, not just driver listing is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: sophistication of interaction analysis, not just driver listing is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: sophistication of interaction analysis, not just driver listing is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Clarity and honesty of the visual map 20%	Communication is publication-ready: clarity and honesty of the visual map is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: clarity and honesty of the visual map is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: clarity and honesty of the visual map is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: clarity and honesty of the visual map is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Written analysis and presentation 20%	Communication is publication-ready: written analysis and presentation is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: written analysis and presentation is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: written analysis and presentation is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: written analysis and presentation is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.